

Marks : 15

Name :

Duration : 30 Minutes

Exam No. :

1. Extract-Based Comprehension Questions with Answers

Extract 1:

"Driving from my parent's home to Cochin last Friday morning, I saw my mother, beside me, doze, open mouthed, her face ashen like that of a corpse..."

1. **Why does the poet compare her mother's face to that of a corpse?** Answer: The poet compares her mother's face to a corpse to emphasize her frailty, pale complexion, and signs of ageing, which fill her with pain and fear of loss.
2. **What does this image suggest about the poet's feelings?** Answer: The image reflects the poet's deep concern, fear of separation, and the inevitability of death that looms over her ageing mother.

Extract 2:

"...but soon put that thought away, and looked out at young trees sprinting, the merry children spilling out of their homes."

3. **What does the poet do to distract herself?** Answer: The poet looks at the vibrant scenery outside, such as sprinting trees and happy children, to shift her focus from the painful thought of her mother's ageing.
4. **What do the 'young trees' and 'merry children' signify?** Answer: They signify youth, life, energy, and renewal, offering a stark contrast to the poet's mother's fragility and ageing.

Extract 3:

"Driving from my parent's home to Cochin last Friday morning, I saw my mother, beside me, doze, open mouthed, her face ashen like that of a corpse..."

Questions:

1. **Why does the poet compare her mother's face to that of a corpse?** Answer: The comparison emphasizes her mother's frailty and lifeless appearance, reflecting the poet's fear of ageing and mortality.

2. **What emotions does the poet feel upon seeing her mother in this state?** *Answer:* The poet experiences pain, fear, and a sense of helplessness at the thought of losing her mother.
3. **What does the imagery used in this extract signify?** *Answer:* The imagery symbolizes the inevitable passage of time and the transient nature of life.
4. **How does this part of the poem set the tone?** *Answer:* It sets a melancholic tone, highlighting themes of ageing and the poet's inner conflict.
5. **What relationship is depicted in this extract?** *Answer:* The close and deeply emotional bond between the poet and her mother is portrayed.

Extract 4:

"...but soon put that thought away, and looked out at young trees sprinting, the merry children spilling out of their homes."

Questions:

1. **Why does the poet turn her attention away from her mother?** *Answer:* The poet distracts herself from the painful thought of her mother's ageing by observing the vibrant scenery outside.
2. **What do the 'young trees sprinting' symbolize?** *Answer:* They symbolize energy, life, and renewal, creating a contrast with her mother's frail state.
3. **How do the 'merry children' influence the tone of the poem?** *Answer:* They bring an element of joy and vitality, contrasting the gloom and sorrow in the poet's mind.
4. **What does this shift in imagery signify?** *Answer:* It signifies the poet's attempt to find solace in the vibrancy of life outside her immediate grief.
5. **What theme is reinforced in this extract?** *Answer:* The theme of contrasting life's vibrancy with ageing and mortality is reinforced.

Extract 5:

"After the airport's security check, standing a few yards away, I looked again at her, wan, pale as a late winter's moon and felt that old familiar ache..."

Questions:

1. **Why does the poet compare her mother to the late winter's moon?** *Answer:* The comparison highlights her mother's waning vitality and approaching end, just like the fading late winter moon.

2. **What does ‘old familiar ache’ signify?** *Answer:* It signifies the poet’s childhood fear of separation and loss, which resurfaces as she observes her mother’s frailty.
3. **Why is the setting of the airport significant?** *Answer:* The airport symbolizes departure and separation, amplifying the poet’s fear of losing her mother.
4. **What mood is created in this extract?** *Answer:* A melancholic and reflective mood is created.
5. **What emotions dominate this part of the poem?** *Answer:* Fear, sorrow, and longing dominate the poet’s emotions.

Extract 6:

"...but all I said was, see you soon, Amma, all I did was smile and smile and smile..."

Questions:

1. **Why does the poet choose to smile while bidding farewell?** *Answer:* The smile is an effort to hide her sorrow and reassure her mother, masking her emotional pain.
2. **What does the phrase ‘see you soon’ signify?** *Answer:* It signifies hope and the desire to hold onto the connection with her mother despite her fear of separation.
3. **How does the repetition of ‘smile’ contribute to the poem’s impact?** *Answer:* The repetition emphasizes the poet’s emotional struggle to appear composed while confronting deep sorrow.
4. **What does this part of the poem reflect about human nature?** *Answer:* It reflects the tendency to suppress emotions and maintain outward composure during difficult moments.
5. **What theme is evident in this farewell scene?** *Answer:* The theme of love and the inevitability of separation is evident.

Extract 7:

"Her face ashen like that of a corpse and pale as a late winter’s moon."

Questions:

1. **What dual imagery is used to describe the poet’s mother?** *Answer:* The mother’s face is compared to a corpse and the late winter’s moon, symbolizing frailty and mortality.
2. **Why does the poet use these comparisons?** *Answer:* The comparisons emphasize her mother’s physical decline and evoke fear of impending loss.

3. **What contrasting elements are used in the poem?** *Answer:* The poet contrasts the lifeless imagery of her mother with the energetic, lively imagery of young trees and children.
4. **How does this extract contribute to the poem's tone?** *Answer:* It adds to the melancholic tone and deepens the reflection on ageing and separation.
5. **What is the central idea conveyed through this imagery?** *Answer:* The inevitability of death and the transient nature of life are central ideas conveyed.

Assertion-Reasoning Questions with Answers

1. **Assertion (A):** The poet compares her mother to the late winter's moon. **Reason (R):** The moon symbolizes waning life and approaching death.
Answer: a) Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.
2. **Assertion (A):** The poet looks outside at young trees sprinting. **Reason (R):** She wants to avoid confronting her mother's mortality.
Answer: a) Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.
3. **Assertion (A):** The poet compares her mother's face to a late winter's moon. **Reason (R):** The late winter moon symbolizes aging and dimness.
Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.
4. **Assertion (A):** The poet feels an old familiar ache. **Reason (R):** The ache stems from the fear of losing her mother, a fear rooted in childhood.
Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.
5. **Assertion (A):** The merry children spilling out of their homes bring relief to the poet. **Reason (R):** The children's liveliness contrasts with the poet's somber mood and her mother's frailty.
Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.

6. **Assertion (A):** The young trees are described as sprinting. **Reason (R):** The poet uses the metaphor of sprinting trees to depict life and movement, in contrast to her mother's stillness.

Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.

7. **Assertion (A):** The poet smiled and said, "See you soon, Amma." **Reason (R):** The parting words and smile were meant to mask her worry and offer comfort.

Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.

8. **Assertion (A):** The poem explores the theme of aging and its impact. **Reason (R):** The poet depicts the frailty of her mother as a reminder of life's transient nature.

Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.

9. **Assertion (A):** The poet shifts her focus to the outside world during the journey.

Reason (R): This shift symbolizes her attempt to avoid confronting her pain.

Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.

10. **Assertion (A):** The poem is written in free verse. **Reason (R):** The poem's structure reflects the poet's stream of consciousness.

Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.

11. **Assertion (A):** The ashen face of the mother is compared to a corpse. **Reason (R):** This comparison underscores the poet's fear of mortality.

Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.

12. **Assertion (A):** The poet uses vivid imagery to describe her emotions and surroundings.

Reason (R): Imagery enhances the emotional depth and contrasts in the poem.

Answer: Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.

Competency-Based Short Questions for 3 Marks

1. How does the poet deal with her fears about her mother's ageing?

Answer: She diverts her attention to the vibrant sights outside the car and later bids her mother farewell with a reassuring smile to mask her emotions.

2. What are the contrasting images in the poem?

Answer: The poem contrasts the mother's frailty and ageing with the vibrant energy of the young trees and children outside, symbolizing life and renewal.

3. What emotions does the poet experience as she looks at her mother?

Answer: The poet feels pain and sadness as she notices her mother's frailty, and a deep fear of losing her, which is tied to her childhood fear of separation.

4. What significance does the comparison of the mother's face to a corpse hold?

Answer: The comparison highlights the mother's ageing and lifeless appearance, evoking the poet's realization of mortality and the inevitability of loss.

5. How does the poet use contrasting imagery in the poem?

Answer: The poet contrasts her mother's frail appearance with vibrant images like 'young trees sprinting' and 'merry children,' symbolizing vitality and the cycle of life.

6. Why does the poet use the image of 'young trees sprinting'?

Answer: The image symbolizes renewal, energy, and life's progression, creating a stark contrast to her mother's stillness and old age.

7. What does the late winter's moon symbolize in the poem?

Answer: It symbolizes decay and waning life, reflecting the fading vitality of the poet's mother.

8. How does the poet's smile at the end convey her emotions?

Answer: Her smile hides her sorrow and fear, attempting to reassure her mother and maintain composure despite the emotional struggle.

9. Why does the poet look away from her mother during the car ride?

Answer: The poet distracts herself from the painful thought of her mother's ageing and mortality by focusing on lively sights outside.

10. What is the significance of the parting words "see you soon, Amma"?

Answer: These words reflect hope and the desire to stay connected, offering emotional reassurance despite the fear of separation.

11. How is the theme of mortality explored in the poem?

Answer: Mortality is explored through the poet's reflection on her mother's ageing and the realization of the inevitability of death and separation.

12. What message does the poem convey about relationships?

Answer: The poem conveys the importance of cherishing relationships and moments with loved ones, especially as time and ageing bring inevitable changes.

Value-Based Short Questions for 2 Marks

1. What value does the poem highlight about the bond between a mother and child?

Answer: The poem highlights the deep emotional connection and unconditional love between a mother and child, emphasizing the inevitable pain of separation.

2. How does the poem reflect the importance of cherishing relationships? *Answer:* It urges us to value and cherish our loved ones, especially ageing parents, as life is fleeting and time is irreversible.

3. What message does the poem give about the inevitability of ageing? *Answer:* The poem conveys that ageing is a natural process, reminding us to respect, care for, and support elderly parents as they become more vulnerable.

4. How does the poet inspire resilience in the face of sorrow? *Answer:* By smiling and saying "see you soon," the poet exemplifies emotional strength, masking sorrow with hope and optimism despite inner pain.

5. What value is conveyed through the poet's observations of youth outside? *Answer:* The imagery of youthful vitality underscores the cyclic nature of life and the value of balancing acceptance of ageing with appreciation for renewal.

6. What lesson does the poem offer about confronting mortality? *Answer:* It teaches us to accept the reality of mortality with grace, focusing on making the most of our time with loved ones.

7. How does the poem emphasize the role of emotional support? *Answer:* Through her reassuring smile and farewell, the poet shows the importance of providing comfort and hope to loved ones during difficult times.

8. What does the poet's childhood fear represent? *Answer:* It symbolizes the universal human anxiety about separation and loss, which persists as a recurring ache throughout life.

9. **How is the poet's relationship with her mother portrayed?** *Answer:* The relationship is filled with love, care, and empathy, as the poet deeply fears her mother's eventual departure yet treasures their bond.
10. **What value can be drawn from the poet's acceptance of reality?** *Answer:* The poet demonstrates the value of emotional maturity, balancing sorrow with hope and acceptance of life's inevitable transitions.
11. **What does the poet's smile signify at the end of the poem?** *Answer:* Her smile is an attempt to hide her sorrow, reassure her mother, and convey hope despite her underlying fear of loss.

Long Question and Answer

1. Question: What values does the poem highlight about the relationship between a mother and child?

Answer: Introduction: Kamala Das' *My Mother at Sixty-Six* portrays the deeply emotional bond between a mother and child, emphasizing love, care, and the pain of separation.

Content: The poet's reflection on her mother's frailty triggers a fear of loss, symbolizing the inevitable cycle of life and death. Her attempts to reassure her mother through her smile show the value of emotional support in familial relationships. The poem beautifully highlights how children must cherish and nurture their parents, acknowledging their sacrifices and accepting the natural progression of life.

Conclusion: The poem reinforces values of love, respect, and the fleeting nature of time, urging readers to cherish their relationships with ageing parents.

Theme-Based Question:

2. Question: Discuss the theme of ageing as depicted in *My Mother at Sixty-Six*.

Answer: Introduction: Ageing, as explored in Kamala Das' poem, is portrayed with a sense of poignancy and inevitability. The poem juxtaposes youth with ageing, reflecting on the transient nature of life.

Content: The poet's mother's frailty and pallid appearance signify the physical decline associated with ageing. The comparison of her mother to the late winter's moon symbolizes approaching death. Through vivid contrasts, such as the energy of children versus her mother's stillness, the poet highlights the universal truth of mortality.

Conclusion: The theme of ageing in the poem serves as a reminder of life's impermanence, urging readers to value their relationships and moments with loved ones.

1. Value-Based Question

Question: What values are conveyed in the poem *My Mother at Sixty-Six*?

Answer: Introduction: Kamala Das' *My Mother at Sixty-Six* is a heartfelt reflection on the values of love, care, and emotional resilience in familial relationships. It poignantly captures the bond between a daughter and her ageing mother.

Content: The poem highlights the importance of cherishing relationships, especially with elderly parents, as time is fleeting. The poet's silent observation of her mother's frailty underscores the value of empathy and understanding. By choosing to mask her grief with a reassuring smile, the poet demonstrates emotional strength and the importance of supporting loved ones during vulnerable moments. The contrast between her mother's ageing and the vibrant life outside symbolizes the cyclical nature of life, urging us to balance acceptance of mortality with love and care.

Conclusion: The poem reminds us to cherish our relationships and find strength in moments of vulnerability. It conveys the value of unconditional love and support in navigating the inevitable changes that life brings.

2. Story-Based Question

Question: How does the poem reflect the poet's inner conflict and emotions?

Answer: Introduction: Kamala Das explores her emotional turmoil as she confronts her mother's ageing and the inevitable separation that follows. The poem beautifully captures this inner conflict through vivid imagery and subtle expressions.

Content: The poet's fear of losing her mother is triggered by her frail, corpse-like appearance, which evokes the "old familiar ache" from her childhood. Torn between acceptance of reality and an instinctive desire to escape, she shifts her focus to the lively scenes outside the car, such as 'young trees sprinting' and 'merry children.' This contrast amplifies her inner struggle between despair and hope. Despite her pain, she bids her mother farewell with a smile, masking her sorrow and choosing to offer comfort and reassurance.

Conclusion: The poem reflects the poet's internal conflict between love, grief, and acceptance. It portrays her emotional maturity in balancing personal pain with the need to support her mother during fragile moments.

3. Theme-Based Question

Question: Discuss the central theme of ageing and mortality as depicted in the poem.

Answer: Introduction: Ageing and mortality are central themes in *My Mother at Sixty-Six*. Kamala Das reflects on the inevitability of growing old and the transient nature of life through her poignant observations of her mother.

Content: The poet describes her mother's pale, corpse-like face to emphasize her physical decline and approaching end. The metaphor of the "late winter's moon" further highlights the fragility and fading vitality of her mother. The lively imagery of 'young trees' and 'merry children' contrasts starkly with her mother's stillness, symbolizing the cycle of life where youth and renewal coexist with ageing and decay. The poem conveys the universal truth of mortality, while also exploring how it impacts personal relationships.

Conclusion: The poem serves as a reminder of life's impermanence and encourages readers to cherish their loved ones while accepting the reality of ageing and mortality.

4. Character-Based Question

Question: How does the poet portray her mother in *My Mother at Sixty-Six*?

Answer: Introduction: Kamala Das provides a vivid portrayal of her mother, emphasizing her vulnerability and frailty. The poet's description reflects both her mother's physical appearance and her emotional bond with her.

Content: The poet's mother is depicted as an ageing figure whose frailty is highlighted by her ashen face, likened to a corpse. This imagery conveys her physical decline and waning vitality. The comparison to the "late winter's moon" symbolizes her fragility and approaching end. Despite her mother's physical state, the poet's words reveal deep love and admiration for her. Her mother's silent acceptance of ageing is contrasted with the poet's inner turmoil, further enriching her character portrayal.

Conclusion: Through a delicate interplay of imagery and emotion, Kamala Das portrays her mother as a figure of love, frailty, and resilience, reflecting the inevitable passage of time.

5. Article-Based Question

Title: *Cherishing the Cycle of Life*

Life is a tapestry woven with threads of vitality and frailty, youth and ageing. Kamala Das' poem *My Mother at Sixty-Six* captures this intricate balance with profound sensitivity.

The poem presents a poignant exploration of the relationship between a daughter and her ageing mother. Through vivid contrasts—her mother's frailty versus the vibrancy of trees and children—it reflects the cyclical nature of life. The poet's inner conflict, triggered by her

mother's pale, corpse-like face, underscores the universal fear of loss and separation. Yet, her parting smile conveys resilience and hope, symbolizing the strength to face life's inevitable transitions.

Kamala Das reminds readers to value and cherish their relationships, especially with parents. In the whirlwind of life's demands, it is essential to pause, reflect, and nurture the bonds that shape our identity.

6. Speech-Based Question

Title: *Life's Cycle: Cherishing Our Loved Ones*

Good morning, everyone.

Today, I want to reflect on the powerful emotions captured in Kamala Das' poem *My Mother at Sixty-Six*. The poem beautifully explores the theme of ageing and the bond between a mother and child.

As the poet watches her frail, ageing mother, she is overwhelmed by fear and grief. Yet, she reminds us of the importance of embracing these moments with love and care. The contrast between her mother's stillness and the lively imagery of sprinting trees and merry children symbolizes the continuous cycle of life. The poet's farewell, marked by a smile, teaches us resilience in the face of sorrow.

Let us cherish our relationships, find strength in moments of vulnerability, and celebrate life's fleeting beauty. Thank you.

7. Conversation-Based Question

Question: Write a conversation between the poet and her mother after the journey.

Answer:

Poet: Amma, are you feeling tired? You were dozing in the car earlier.

Mother: I'm fine, dear. Just a little tired—it happens with age.

Poet: (pauses) Amma, you know, I was thinking... I've never noticed how fragile you've become.

Mother: (smiling) It's natural, my child. Age doesn't spare anyone.

Poet: But it frightens me... the thought of losing you.

Mother: Don't be afraid, dear. I've lived a full life, and your love is my greatest strength.

Poet: (smiles weakly) I will always cherish every moment with you, Amma.

Mother: That's all I could ask for, my child. Live fully and keep smiling—it's the best gift you can give me.

